
Isaac Albéniz

1860–1909, SPANISH

Composer and piano virtuoso Albéniz was born in Catalonia, Spain. A child prodigy, he gave his first public performance as a pianist at the age of five and was toured internationally by his parents before settling to a serious musical education at the Brussels Conservatory in 1876. Studying under Spanish nationalist composer Felipe Pedrell in Barcelona in 1883 influenced him to write music reflecting regional varieties of Spanish folk song. Many of these piano pieces, published in *Suite Española* and *Cantos de España*, are now better known in arrangements for classical guitar. Not well received in his own country, Albéniz spent most of his later years in England and France. He wrote orchestral pieces, and in the 1890s extended his range into operas and operettas, but his finest work resulted from a late return to piano solo with the four books of the *Iberia* suite, one of the founding masterpieces of modern Spanish music.

KEY WORKS: *Suite Española* (piano solo), Op. 47, 1887; *Cantos de España* (piano solo), 1892; *Catalonia* (orchestral suite), 1899; *Iberia* (piano solo), 1906–1908